

How to Execute the SAA-C03 Plan — Step by Step

This is the "how," not the "what" — use alongside the Study Tracker (which tells you *what* to cover each week). This tells you *exactly what to do* in your daily 2-hour block.

The Daily 2-Hour Block (Learning Weeks 1–8)

Don't just "watch videos for 2 hours." Split every session like this:

Time	Activity
0:00–0:45	Watch Udemy (Maarek) section at 1.25–1.5x speed
0:45–1:00	Immediately do the KodeKloud lab for that exact topic (same day, not later)
1:00–1:20	Write/update your notes (comparison-table style — see template below)
1:20–1:30	5-question self-quiz from memory (no notes) — write down what you got wrong

Why this order matters: Watching video → doing lab → writing notes in the *same session* uses three different memory pathways (visual, hands-on, written) on the same concept while it's fresh. Splitting video-watching and labs across different days is the #1 reason people forget material by week 8.

Don't rewatch the same lecture in both Udemy and KodeKloud. Pick Udemy as primary teaching content. Use KodeKloud purely for its labs/playground — skip its video for topics you already watched in Udemy.

Step-by-Step: A Single Topic (example — "S3 Storage Classes")

1. **Watch** the Udemy lecture once, no pausing, just absorb the shape of it.
2. **Open the KodeKloud lab** (or your own free-tier AWS console if no lab exists) and actually:
 - Create a bucket

- Upload an object
- Change its storage class manually
- Set up a lifecycle rule and watch it apply

3. **Write your note as a comparison, not a transcript.** Bad note: "S3 has Standard, IA, Glacier..." Good note:

Storage Class	Retrieval time	Use case	Min duration charge
Standard	ms	Frequently accessed	none
Standard-IA	ms	Infrequent, needs fast access	30 days
Glacier Instant	ms	Archive, instant retrieval	90 days
Glacier Flexible	mins–hrs	Archive, rare retrieval	90 days
Glacier Deep Archive	hrs	Long-term compliance	180 days

This table format is what actually gets tested — the exam gives you a scenario ("data accessed once a quarter, needs retrieval within minutes") and you match it to a row.

4. **Self-quiz:** close your notes, write 3 scenario questions from memory ("when would you use X over Y"), answer them, then check against your notes.

Repeat this exact 4-step loop for every service in the tracker checklist.

Weekly Rhythm

Learning weeks (1–8):

- Mon–Fri: daily 2-hour blocks (topic learning as above)
- Sat: 1 hour — review the week's notes only (no new content), fix any comparison tables that felt shaky
- Sun: off, or catch-up buffer if you fell behind

Practice test weeks (9–11):

- This phase works differently — see below.
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How to Run the Practice Test Phase (Weeks 9–11) Properly

Most people waste this phase by just grinding tests without reviewing well. Do this instead:

1. **Day A (needs ~2 hrs, use a weekend or combine 2 weekday sessions):**

- Take one **full 65-question timed test** in one sitting, no pausing, no notes
- Don't review yet — just note your score

2. **Day B (next available day, 1 session):**

- Go through **every wrong answer AND every answer you guessed on** (even if correct)
- For each one, write in an error log (template below) — don't just read the explanation and move on, write it in your own words
- Go back to your week 1–8 notes for that specific service and re-read that section

3. **Day C:**

- Before the next full test, spend 20–30 min re-reading only your error log from the past week
- Then take the next full test

Error Log Template:

Date	Question topic	Why I got it wrong	Correct concept (in my own words)	Reviewed again?
	e.g. "NAT Gateway vs NAT Instance"	Confused cost model	NAT Gateway = AWS managed, scales, no SSH; NAT Instance = self-managed, cheaper for low traffic	[]

By week 11 you should have a fairly long error log — **skim the entire log the night before the exam**. This is your single highest-value asset going into test day, more useful than any last-minute video.

Rules to Actually Follow (not just read)

- **Never skip the lab step**, even when tempted to "just watch two more videos." Passive video-watching without hands-on practice is the single biggest reason people fail SAA-C03 despite "finishing the course."
- **Never let notes become a copy of the video**. If you're writing full sentences describing what a service does, stop — convert it to a comparison table or a "when to use X vs Y" line instead.
- **Don't move to a new topic if your 5-question self-quiz score was below 3/5**. Spend 10 extra minutes on that topic instead — it compounds later

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- **Log every practice-test mistake, even lucky guesses.** A correct guess is a knowledge gap wearing a disguise.
- **If a week runs short, don't compress the lab step to save time — compress the note-writing instead.** Labs are what actually builds intuition for the scenario questions; notes are just backup.

Quick Daily Checklist (print this or keep it open)

- ☐ Watched today's video segment
- ☐ Did the matching hands-on lab
- ☐ Wrote/updated a comparison-table note
- ☐ Did a 5-question self-quiz from memory
- ☐ Logged anything I got wrong

If you can honestly check all 5 boxes at the end of a session, that session counted. If you only watched video, it mostly didn't.